✦ DEBATE PREP PACKAGE

Should the U.S. recognize Somaliland as a sovereign nation?

Everything you need to understand the topic from scratch and argue **both** sides: the background, the history, the neighbors, the strongest arguments, evidence cards, and cross-examination practice.

The topic in 30 seconds

Somaliland is the northern strip of Somalia, along the Gulf of Aden. It has governed itself since **1991**, with its own government, army, money, passports and elections. On paper, though, almost every country still treats it as part of **Somalia**.

Israel became the first country to recognize it, in **December 2025**. The **United States has not**. A State Department report to Congress in 2026 said the U.S. still considers Somaliland part of Somalia.

The debate comes down to two things the U.S. cares about: **rewarding a peaceful democracy** (Aff) versus **keeping borders stable and partners happy** (Neg).

✧ Start here

📘

1. Topic Basics

Where it is, what "recognition" means, key words.

🕰️

2. History

From British colony to 30+ years of self-rule.

🗺️

3. Neighbors & Map

Who's nearby, who wants what, and the map.

🟦

4. Affirmative

Reasons to recognize, plus the attacks to expect.

🟥

5. Negative

Reasons not to, plus the attacks to expect.

📄

6. Evidence Cards

Your Aff and Neg cards, and how to cut cards.

🎤

7. Cross-Ex Practice

Tough questions with model answers.

🧠

8. Debate Skills

Claim → proof → so what, and mistakes to avoid.

🔗

9. Sources

Every link, plus what still needs checking.

✧ Current status (as of October 2026)

Question	Answer
Has the U.S. recognized Somaliland?	**No.** It follows a "One Somalia" policy, which the State Department reaffirmed in a 2026 report to Congress.
Has anyone recognized it?	**Israel**, on December 26, 2025. No other country has followed.
Is the U.S. talking to Somaliland?	**Yes, unofficially.** U.S. officials have visited, and Somaliland's president met Senator Ted Cruz in Washington in September 2026.
Who supports recognition in Congress?	Mostly some Republicans, including Sen. Ted Cruz. A bill, H.R. 3992, calls for recognition.

⚠ WATCH OUT FOR FAKES

In January 2026 a **fake press release** claiming the U.S. had recognized Somaliland spread online. The U.S. Embassy in Mogadishu called it false. Always check claims about recognition against a reliable source.

💡 PDF VERSION

Need it offline or at school? Every page is also a PDF in the pdf-version folder, or get everything in one file: complete-guide.pdf.

💡 HOW TO USE THIS SITE

Read the pages in order the first time. Before a round, review Affirmative, Negative and Cross-Ex. Items marked VERIFY still need a source checked before you quote them. And always explain arguments **in your own words**.

✦ STEP 1

Topic Basics

Starting from zero: where Somaliland is, what "recognizing" a country means, and why the U.S. cares.

✧ Where is it?

Find the **Horn of Africa** on a map: the pointy part on the east side of Africa that sticks out toward Arabia.

- **Somalia** runs along that coast and is shaped like a big "7".
- **Somaliland** is the **top part of the 7**, the northern strip along the **Gulf of Aden**.
- Its neighbors are **Djibouti** (west), **Ethiopia** (south) and the rest of **Somalia** (east).
- Capital: **Hargeisa**. Main port: **Berbera**.
- Across the water is **Yemen**, where the Houthis are.

See the full map on the Neighbors & Map page.

✧ What does "recognize as a sovereign nation" mean?

Sovereign means a country rules itself, with nobody above it in charge.

Recognizing a country means the rest of the world officially says, "Yes, you are a real country." A recognized country can:

- have embassies with real ambassadors
- sign official treaties and trade deals
- join groups like the United Nations
- get loans from the World Bank and similar lenders

Somaliland already does most of what a country does: its own government, police, army, money (the Somaliland shilling), passports and elections. But on paper, almost the whole world still treats it as **part of Somalia**.

💡 **COMPARISON YOU ALREADY KNOW**

Taiwan also runs itself like a country, but most nations, including the U.S., don't officially recognize it. Somaliland is in a similar spot.

✧ Why does the U.S. care?

1. **Shipping.** Ships going to and from the Red Sea and the Suez Canal pass close to Somaliland. The Houthis in Yemen have attacked ships there.
2. **China.** Djibouti, right next door, has the main **U.S. base** in Africa and also **China's first overseas military base**.
3. **Terrorism.** The U.S. works with Somalia's government to fight **al-Shabaab**, a terrorist group linked to al-Qaeda. Somalia strongly opposes Somaliland breaking away.
4. **Taiwan.** Somaliland and Taiwan opened offices in each other's capitals in 2020, which angered China.

✧ The big idea behind the debate

AFF Reward success

Somaliland is peaceful and democratic, and it has run itself for over 30 years. Shouldn't that count?

NEG Keep things stable

If regions that want out get recognized, many countries could break apart. Upsetting Somalia and U.S. partners could also hurt the U.S.

✧ Key words

Word	Meaning
Sovereignty	A country's right to rule itself.
Recognition	Other countries officially accepting you as a country.
De facto	True in real life. Somaliland is *de facto* independent.
De jure	True on paper, by law. Somaliland is *de jure* part of Somalia.
Secession	A region breaking away from a country.
Territorial integrity	The idea that a country's borders shouldn't be broken up.
"One Somalia" policy	The official U.S. position that Somalia, including Somaliland, is one country.
Montevideo Convention	A 1933 treaty, signed by the U.S., that lists four things that make a country a country.
Horn of Africa	The region with Somalia, Somaliland, Ethiopia, Djibouti and Eritrea.
AFRICOM	U.S. Africa Command, the part of the U.S. military in charge of operations in Africa.

Somalia or Somali?

It works like *America* and *American*:

- **Somalia** is the **country**: "The U.S. works with **Somalia**."
- **Somali describes** people or things from there, or the language: "**Somali** forces," "she speaks **Somali**."
- People from Somaliland are **Somalilanders**.

> ⚠ **AUTOCORRECT ALERT**
>
> Your keyboard may change "Somalia" to "Somali." Proofread your written speech before printing it.

✦ STEP 2

History

How Somaliland went from a British colony to joining Somalia, being bombed by its own government, breaking away, and building a democracy from scratch.

The whole story in one sentence: Somaliland was a separate colony, joined Somalia in 1960, was treated badly and then bombed, broke away in 1991, and built its own peaceful democracy while the south fell into war.

✧ Timeline

Before 1880s

Clans and herders

Somali people lived across the Horn of Africa, mostly as **herders** of camels, goats and sheep. Society was organized into **clans** (large family groups).

Most people in central and western Somaliland belong to the **Isaaq** clan. Around **Las Anod** in the east, most belong to other clans, such as the **Dhulbahante**. This explains the Las Anod dispute today.

1880s

Britain arrives

Britain made the north a **protectorate**. It held the port of **Aden** in Yemen, across the water, and needed **meat** to feed its soldiers there. **Italy** took the south, and **France** took what is now Djibouti.

June 26, 1960

Independence

British Somaliland became an independent country and was recognized by about **35 countries**.

July 1, 1960

Union with the south

Five days later, it chose to join former Italian Somaliland to form **Somalia**. The capital was **Mogadishu**, in the south, so the north quickly lost power and jobs.

Somaliland argues the **act of union was never properly ratified** by both sides.

1961

The north says no

In the vote on Somalia's new constitution, many northerners boycotted, and most northern voters **voted against it**. It passed anyway because of southern votes. Sources disagree on the exact date and numbers. VERIFY

1969

Dictatorship

General **Siad Barre** took power in a coup.

1977–78

The Ogaden War

Somalia invaded Ethiopia to take its Somali-populated region and **lost**. The government became weaker and harsher.

1981

Rebellion

Northerners formed a rebel group, the **Somali National Movement (SNM)**.

1988

The bombing of Hargeisa

Barre's government **bombed Hargeisa** and other northern cities. Much of Hargeisa was destroyed, and **tens of thousands** of Isaaq civilians were killed. Many call it the **Isaaq genocide**. Death estimates vary a lot. VERIFY

May 1991

Breaking away

Barre's government collapsed in January. In May, northern leaders met in **Burao** and declared Somaliland independent again.

1993

The Borama conference

Clan **elders** held a peace conference in **Borama** and built a government themselves, **without foreign help or money**. Parliament includes a **House of Elders** (the *Guurti*), mixing tradition with democracy.

1993 →

Meanwhile, in the south

Civil war, *Black Hawk Down* (1993), years with no real government, and later **al-Shabaab**. The U.S. didn't recognize a Somali government again until **2013**.

2003

An 80-vote election

Somaliland's first presidential election was decided by about **80 votes**. The losing side disputed the count but took it to **court**, the result stood, and there was no war. In **2010** that challenger won, and the president handed over power.

2005

The AU's own investigators

An **African Union** fact-finding mission called Somaliland's case **"historically unique and self-justified."** The AU never acted on the report. VERIFY (quoted in several articles; original report not opened)

2020

Taiwan ties

Somaliland and Taiwan opened offices in each other's capitals. China pressured Somaliland, and Somaliland refused to back down.

2023

Las Anod

Fighting broke out around **Las Anod**. Local forces pushed Somaliland's troops out. The area later formed its own government, now the **North Eastern State**, which joined **Somalia**. Somalia's president attended its leaders' inauguration in January 2026.

Jan 2024

The Ethiopia deal

Ethiopia and Somaliland signed a deal: sea access for Ethiopia, possible recognition for Somaliland. Somalia was furious. In December 2024, Ethiopia backed off (the **Ankara Declaration**).

Nov 2024

Peaceful handover

Opposition candidate **Abdirahman "Irro" Abdullahi** beat the sitting president, who stepped down peacefully.

Dec 26, 2025

Israel recognizes Somaliland

The first country to do so. The African Union, the EU, Egypt, Saudi Arabia and China condemned it.

2026

The U.S. holds its position

A State Department report to Congress reaffirmed that the U.S. considers Somaliland part of Somalia, while exploring more engagement with Somaliland. President Irro visited Washington in September and met Sen. Ted Cruz.

✧ How each side uses the history

AFF

- **Old borders, not new ones.** Somaliland was independent in 1960 and wants those same borders back. It's restoring an old country, not creating a new one.
- **It rebuilt itself.** Even after the 1988 bombings, Somaliland rebuilt and has run its own country for over 30 years.
- **The deal was broken by Somalia.** Choosing to join doesn't mean accepting being bombed by your own government.

NEG

- **It joined willingly.** Somaliland chose to join Somalia in 1960, and nobody forced it. You can't just leave because you're unhappy with how things turned out.
- **Domino effect.** If any region can leave after a bad government, lots of regions could leave.
- **Not everyone agrees.** People in Las Anod, inside Somaliland's 1960 borders, chose Somalia instead.

✧ Check yourself

✦ **Why might the people of Las Anod not want to be part of Somaliland?**

Most belong to a different clan (mainly the Dhulbahante) and feel more loyal to Somalia than to Somaliland's government, which is led mostly by the Isaaq.

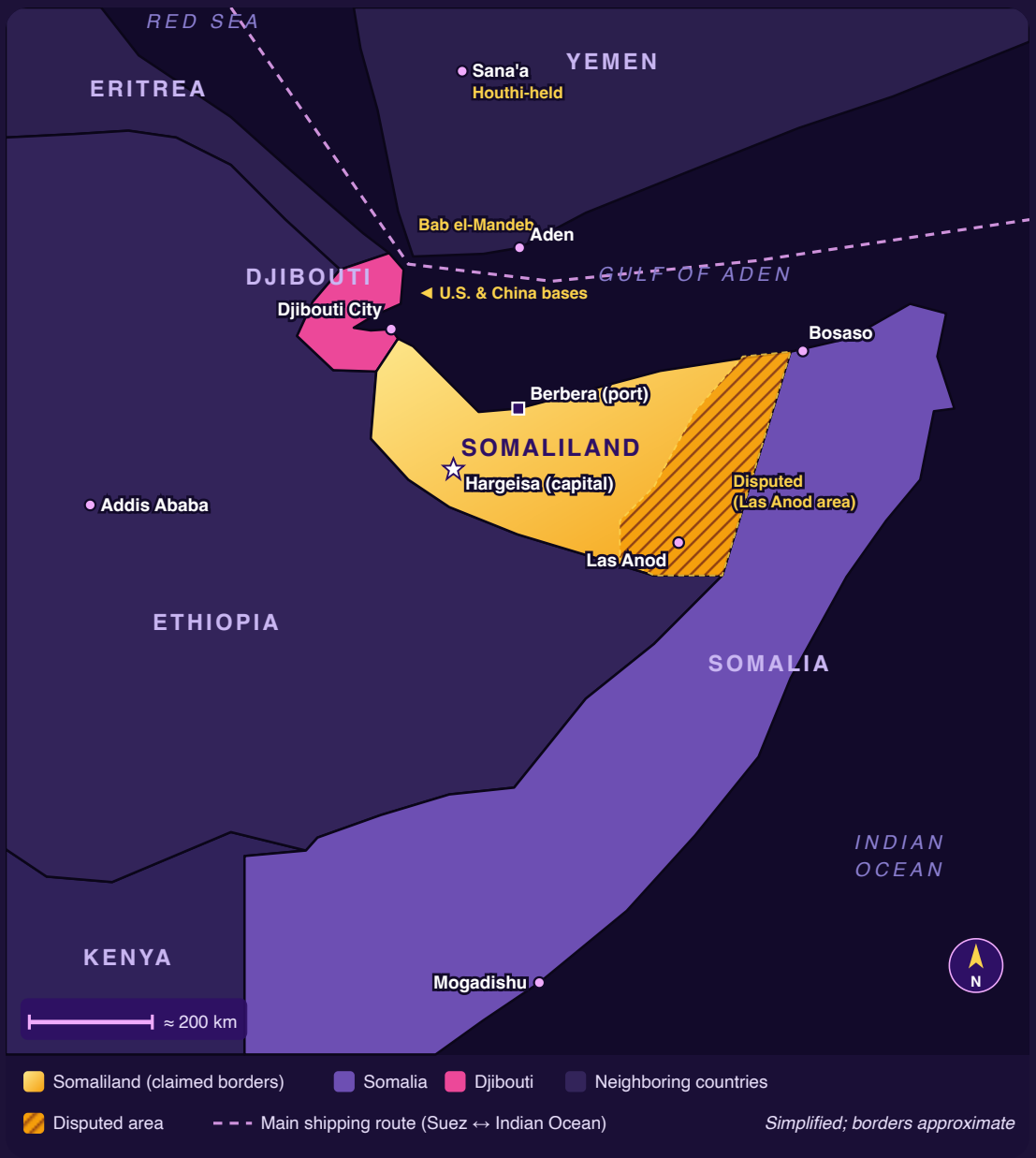
✦ **Why does Somaliland say it isn't creating new borders?**

It was briefly an independent country in 1960, recognized by about 35 countries, and it only wants those same borders back.

STEP 3

Neighbors & Map

Somaliland sits on one of the busiest shipping routes in the world, surrounded by countries that each want something different.



Simplified map. Borders are approximate. The disputed area is shown roughly; it is the region around Las Anod that now belongs to Somalia's North Eastern State but is still claimed by Somaliland.

💡 **WHAT TO NOTICE ON THE MAP**

- **Berbera** sits right on the Gulf of Aden, close to the main shipping route.
- **Djibouti** is tiny but hosts both a U.S. base and China's base, only a few miles apart.
- **Ethiopia** has no coastline at all.
- The **Bab el-Mandeb** strait is the narrow gate between the Red Sea and the Gulf of Aden, right next to Yemen's Houthis.

✧ The close neighbors

🇪🇹 Ethiopia: wants the sea

- Well over **100 million people** but **no coastline**. It lost its coast when **Eritrea** became independent in 1993.
- Almost all its trade goes through **Djibouti's** port, which is expensive.
- **January 2024:** it signed a deal (an "MoU") with Somaliland: coastline for a naval base in exchange for **possible recognition**.
- Somalia was furious. **Turkey** stepped in, and in December 2024 Ethiopia backed off and promised to respect Somalia's borders (the **Ankara Declaration**).
- **The twist:** Ethiopia also has troops in Somalia fighting al-Shabaab. That's why the White House warned the deal "threatens to disrupt the fight" against al-Shabaab.

🇩🇯 Djibouti: the competitor

- A tiny country that earns money from **its port** and from renting land for **military bases** to the U.S. (Camp Lemonnier), **China**, France, Japan and others.
- If Somaliland's port of **Berbera** grows, Djibouti could **lose business**, so it has a reason to side with Somalia.
- In January 2026, Djibouti sent a delegation to Las Anod for the inauguration of the **North Eastern State's** leaders.

🇾🇪 Yemen and the Houthis: the danger across the water

- The **Houthis** control much of Yemen and have attacked ships in the Red Sea since late 2023.
- After Israel recognized Somaliland, the Houthi leader **threatened to target any Israeli presence** there (January 2026).
- AFF Somaliland could help the U.S. watch the Houthis.
- NEG Recognition could make Somaliland, and Americans there, a **target**.

🇪🇷 Eritrea: Somalia's friend

In **October 2024**, Eritrea's, Egypt's and Somalia's leaders met in Asmara and agreed to work together more closely, a move widely seen as pushing back on Ethiopia's sea deal.

✧ The faraway players

Country	Side	Why
🇹🇷 **Turkey**	Somalia	Somalia's closest ally. Runs a big military training base in Mogadishu and brokered the Ethiopia–Somalia peace.
🇪🇬 **Egypt**	Somalia	Fighting with **Ethiopia** over a giant dam on the Nile, so it backs Ethiopia's rivals. Signed a defense pact with Somalia in 2024 and sent troops and weapons.
🇸🇦 **Saudi Arabia**	Somalia	Condemned Israel's recognition and reportedly pressured other countries not to follow.
🇦🇪 **UAE**	Leans Somaliland	A UAE company, **DP World**, runs and expanded the **Berbera** port.
🇮🇱 **Israel**	Somaliland	The only country to recognize it (December 2025). Wants a partner near the Houthis.
🇨🇳 **China**	Somalia	Angry about Somaliland's ties with Taiwan. Has a military base in Djibouti.
🇹🇼 **Taiwan**	Somaliland	Swapped offices with Somaliland in 2020.
🌍 **African Union**	Somalia	Says recognition would be a "dangerous precedent," even though its own 2005 mission called the case unique.

✧ Why this matters in a round

NEG A crowded, dangerous neighborhood

"Turkey, Egypt, Saudi Arabia, China, Djibouti, the African Union: almost everyone is on Somalia's side. The U.S. would be stepping into a fight with half the region."

AFF An opportunity

"Ethiopia, the UAE, Israel and Taiwan already work with Somaliland. The region is already moving toward it. The U.S. can lead instead of falling behind China and Turkey."

✧ Check yourself

Why does Ethiopia care so much about Somaliland?

Ethiopia has no coastline and depends on Djibouti's expensive port. Somaliland could give it its own access to the sea.

Why might Djibouti not want Somaliland to succeed?

Djibouti makes money from its port. If Berbera grows, ships and trade could go there instead.

Pick a faraway country and use it for one side.

Example (Neg): "Egypt and Turkey are already sending troops and support to Somalia. If the U.S. recognizes Somaliland, Somalia could lean even more on them, and the U.S. would lose influence."

✦ STEP 4 · AFFIRMATIVE

The case for recognition

Two strong contentions that are hard to attack, plus backup reasons. Each one has the attack to expect and an answer ready.

💡 **FORMAT FOR EVERY ARGUMENT**

Claim (what you're saying) → **Proof** (a fact or evidence) → **So what** (why the U.S. should care).

✧ Contention 1: Somaliland already IS a country STRONGEST

Claim: Recognition just admits what's already true.

Proof: The **Montevideo Convention (1933)**, which the **U.S. signed**, lists four things that make a country a country:

1. People who live there permanently ✅
2. Territory it controls ✅
3. A government ✅
4. The ability to deal with other countries ✅

Somaliland has had all four for **over 30 years**. The treaty also says a country's existence **doesn't depend** on other countries recognizing it. And Somaliland is a **democracy**: in November 2024 the opposition won, and the sitting president stepped down peacefully.

So what: The U.S. is refusing to admit what its own treaty says. Not recognizing a peaceful democracy tells the world that being democratic gets you nothing, which removes the **incentive** to be democratic.

Attack to expect

NEG "In 2023 it lost Las Anod, and those people joined Somalia. So Somaliland doesn't control its territory, *right?*"

YOU "**No.** Somaliland still controls most of its land, including its capital and its main port. And recognized countries have border disputes too: India and Pakistan both claim Kashmir, and both are recognized. That isn't a reason to deny recognition."

NEG "The U.S. recognizes lots of countries that aren't democracies. Why should democracy matter?"

YOU "Democracy isn't the only reason. It's one good reason among several. Somaliland also meets every part of the Montevideo test and sits in a key location."

⚠ **DON'T OVERCLAIM**

Don't say "almost all U.S. allies are democracies." Saudi Arabia, the UAE and Egypt are close partners and aren't. Say "many of America's closest allies, like the UK and Japan, are democracies."

✧ Contention 2: Somaliland's case is unique STRONG

Claim: Recognizing Somaliland wouldn't set an example for other regions to break away.

Proof:

- **Old wall, not a new wall.** Picture two houses that knocked down the wall between them in 1960. Somaliland wants to put the wall back **exactly where it was**. Most breakaway regions were always part of one house and want to build a **brand-new** wall.
- **Even the African Union agreed.** Its own 2005 fact-finding mission called Somaliland's case "historically unique and self-justified." VERIFY
- **It's happened before. Eritrea** (1993) and **South Sudan** (2011) became countries, and Africa did not break apart.

So what: This knocks out the Neg's breakaway argument before they even make it. Other regions couldn't use Somaliland as an excuse.

💡 **WHY THE AU POINT IS SO STRONG**

The AU **opposes** recognition today. When your **opponent's own side** admits something, the judge believes it. Say: "**Even the African Union**, which opposes recognition, admitted in 2005 that Somaliland's case is unique."

Attack to expect

NEG "The AU today says recognition is a dangerous precedent."

YOU "The AU's own investigators said the opposite. It just never acted on their report."

NEG "Somaliland chose to join Somalia in 1960. Nobody forced it."

YOU "The union was never properly ratified, and northerners voted against the 1961 constitution. And choosing to join doesn't mean accepting being bombed by your own government. Somalia broke the deal, not Somaliland."

✧ Backup reasons

These are good, but easier to attack. Use them as extra support, not as main contentions.

📍 Location, shipping and China

Somaliland sits near the Red Sea shipping route, where the Houthis have attacked ships. Its president has **offered** the U.S. access to the port of **Berbera**. China already has a base next door in Djibouti, about 4 miles from the main U.S. base. Recognizing Somaliland could give the U.S. a **backup partner** in the region. (Your Aff evidence card supports this.)

Weak spot: the Neg will say "we can work with Berbera without recognizing Somaliland." Answer: a real long-term base deal is much easier with a recognized government.

Word choice: say "presence" or "influence," not "dominance." And don't say "we get the ports," because recognition doesn't hand them over.

🇹🇼 Taiwan

In **2020**, Somaliland chose Taiwan over China, even when China pressured it. The U.S. and Somaliland share a goal: **limiting China's influence**. Partners who take risks for U.S. friends deserve support.

Weak spot: "The U.S. doesn't recognize Taiwan either!" Answer: "True, but the U.S. still supports Taiwan strongly. Somaliland took a real risk to stand with a U.S. friend."

🕊️ Democracy (as part of Contention 1)

Somaliland has held several elections. In 2003 the presidential race was decided by about 80 votes, and the dispute went to court instead of to war. In 2024 the opposition won, and the president stepped down. In that region, leaders losing and actually leaving is rare.

✧ Answers to the Neg's best arguments

Neg says	You answer
"We already get the benefits without recognition."	"Without recognition, there are no real embassies, no official treaties, no long-term base agreements. Unofficial ties can be dropped at any time, and China and Turkey are moving faster."
"We'd lose Somalia's help against al-Shabaab."	"Somalia needs U.S. help against al-Shabaab more than the U.S. needs Somalia. It's fighting for its own survival. And the U.S. relationship with Somalia has already changed: most aid was cut and Somali nationals are barred from entering the U.S."
"Our allies would be angry."	"The U.S. recognized **Kosovo** in 2008 even though Serbia and Russia were furious, and it worked out. Someone has to go first, and Israel already did."
"Other regions will break away."	Use Contention 2: unique case, the AU 2005 mission, Eritrea and South Sudan.

🔍 **BEFORE YOU QUOTE**

Check the AU 2005 quote and any death toll for 1988 against a source you can open. See the verify list.

✦ STEP 5 · NEGATIVE

The case against recognition

Two strong contentions that are hard to attack, plus backup reasons. Each one has the attack to expect and an answer ready.

💡 **FORMAT FOR EVERY ARGUMENT**

Claim (what you're saying) → **Proof** (a fact or evidence) → **So what** (why the U.S. should care).

✧ Contention 1: We already get the benefits STRONGEST

Claim: The U.S. can work with Somaliland **without** officially recognizing it.

Proof: U.S. officials have visited Somaliland and discussed more engagement, but the State Department told Congress in 2026 that the U.S. still recognizes Somalia's borders, **including Somaliland**. The U.S. treats **Taiwan** the same way: strong unofficial support, no official recognition.

So what: Why take all the risks (losing Somalia's help against al-Shabaab, angering allies, encouraging breakaways) when we already get most of the benefits?

💡 **WHY IT'S SO STRONG**

It doesn't fight the Aff's facts. It **agrees** Somaliland is a great partner and says "so what, we already work with them." That turns the Aff's democracy, location and Taiwan points into reasons the current setup works.

Attack to expect

AFF "Without recognition, Somaliland can't get World Bank loans, sign official treaties or have real embassies."

YOU "Those things help **Somaliland**, but the question is what's good for the **U.S.** The U.S. gets security cooperation either way, without the risks."

✧ Contention 2: Recognition risks the fight against al-Shabaab

STRONG

Claim: The U.S. and Somalia fight al-Shabaab together, so recognizing Somaliland risks that partnership.

Proof: U.S. airstrikes in Somalia have increased sharply: **over 130 in 2025** and **nearly 70 in the first half of 2026**, done in coordination with Somalia's government. **Hundreds of U.S. troops** are in Somalia helping Somali and African Union forces. Al-Shabaab is linked to al-Qaeda. (Your Neg evidence card.) Back in 2024, the White House warned that Ethiopia's possible recognition of Somaliland "threatens to disrupt the fight" against al-Shabaab.

So what: If Somalia stops working with the U.S., al-Shabaab could grow stronger in East Africa and put **Americans in the region** at risk.

⚠ DON'T OVERCLAIM

- Don't say "terrorism in the U.S." Al-Shabaab mostly attacks in Somalia and nearby countries like Kenya. Say "Americans in East Africa." (In 2020, al-Shabaab attacked a base in Kenya and killed three Americans. VERIFY)
- Don't say Somalia would stop fighting al-Shabaab. It's fighting for its own survival. Say it could stop **working with the U.S.**

Attack to expect

AFF "Somalia needs the U.S. more than the U.S. needs Somalia. They'd never actually cut ties."

YOU "Somalia doesn't have to fully cut ties to hurt us. It could limit where U.S. forces operate, or turn to other partners like Turkey, Egypt or China. Why take the chance when the current partnership works?"

AFF "The U.S. already cut most aid to Somalia and banned Somali nationals. The relationship is already weak."

YOU "Military cooperation is still strong. Over 130 strikes in coordination with Somalia's government in 2025 shows that."

✧ Backup reasons

Good, but easier to attack. Use them as extra support or in cross-ex.

🧩 Other regions will want to break away

In 1964, African countries agreed to **keep the old colonial borders** to avoid endless wars. Groups like the **English-speaking regions of Cameroon** and **Tigray in Ethiopia** have tried to break away. Recognizing Somaliland could encourage them, which could lead to **instability and more fighting**.

Weak spot: the Aff has the AU 2005 mission, Eritrea and South Sudan. Comeback: "Other groups won't care about the details. They'll just see that breaking away **worked**."

🗺️ Somaliland's own borders are disputed

In 2023, fighting broke out around **Las Anod**, and the people there formed their own government that joined **Somalia** instead. Somaliland doesn't even control all the land it claims, so **which borders would the U.S. be recognizing?** This hits the Aff's "same 1960 borders" argument directly.

Weak spot: the Aff will answer with Kashmir. **Word choice:** don't say Somaliland "doesn't know its borders." Say it "doesn't control all the land it claims."

🤝 Allies would be angry

When Israel recognized Somaliland in December 2025, the African Union, the EU, Egypt, Saudi Arabia and China all condemned it, and **no other country followed**. The U.S. needs these partners for trade, security and UN votes.

Weak spot: the Aff will bring up Kosovo (recognized by the U.S. in 2008 despite Serbia and Russia).

📜 It joined willingly

Somaliland **chose** to join Somalia in 1960. You can't just leave a country because you're unhappy with how it turned out. If any region can leave after a bad government, lots of regions could leave.

✧ Answers to the Aff's best arguments

Aff says	You answer
"It meets the Montevideo test; it's already a country."	"Then nothing changes if we don't recognize it. It keeps running itself, and we keep working with it. Recognition only adds risk." Also: "It doesn't control all its territory, as Las Anod shows."
"Its case is unique; no domino effect."	"Other groups won't read an AU report from 2005. They'll see that breaking away worked. And the AU itself now calls recognition a 'dangerous precedent.'"
"It's a democracy; reward it."	"We can reward it with trade, aid and visits without breaking up a partner country."
"We need Berbera to balance China in Djibouti."	"Somaliland has already offered access. We don't need recognition to use a port, and the 2026 State Department report already points to Berbera for engagement."
"Your evidence is old" or "biased."	"The facts haven't changed, and several other sources report the same thing."

✦ STEP 6

Evidence Cards

One card for each side, ready to read, plus how to build and cut your own cards honestly.

✧ What's in a card

1. **Tag:** one short line, in **your own words**, saying what the card proves.
2. **Cite:** author, their qualifications, publication, date and link.
3. **Evidence:** the exact words from the source. **Highlighted** parts are what you read out loud.

✧ Affirmative card

AFF · Location / China — **Meservey, 2021**

China's control of Djibouti puts U.S. forces at risk, so recognizing Somaliland gives the U.S. a backup partner in the region.

Meservey, 2021. Joshua Meservey, Senior Policy Analyst for Africa and the Middle East CHECK BYLINE, Heritage Foundation, "The U.S. Should Recognize Somaliland," October 19, 2021. heritage.org

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Beijing recently built in Djibouti its only overseas military base, a hardened encampment whose quay can support a Chinese aircraft carrier. Beijing's lavish financing of Djiboutian infrastructure has made Djibouti at high risk of debt distress, and **China is by far Djibouti's largest trading partner**. The Chinese government financed—and Chinese companies built—sensitive Djiboutian buildings such as the foreign ministry headquarters and the People's Palace. State-controlled China Merchants Port Holdings manages three of Djibouti Port's terminals. It and four other Chinese companies are involved in various ways in the ownership, construction, and operation of what will be Africa's largest free trade zone, the Djibouti International Free Trade Zone. **Beijing's unparalleled influence in the country has already impeded American operations**—and **positions China to shut down U.S. activity** in the case of a confrontation between the two countries.

EXTRA FACT YOU CAN SAY OUT LOUD

From the same report's footnote 20: in **2018**, lasers fired from the Chinese base targeted U.S. military aircraft and **injured two U.S. airmen**. Say: "The report also notes that..."

⚠ **BE READY FOR**

- **"It's from 2021!"** → "The key facts haven't changed. China's base is still in Djibouti, right next to ours. Old evidence is fine when the facts are still true." VERIFY (find a 2025–26 article showing the base is still active)
- **"Heritage is biased."** → "It's written by an Africa expert, and the report even lists the downsides of recognition."
- **"It never mentions Somaliland."** → This paragraph proves Djibouti is risky. You explain the link: so the U.S. needs a backup partner nearby, Somaliland and its port of Berbera.

✧ Negative card

🟥 **NEG · Al-Shabaab risk** **CRS, 2026**

The U.S. and Somalia fight al-Shabaab together, so recognizing Somaliland risks that partnership.

CRS, 2026. Congressional Research Service (Congress's nonpartisan research office), "Somalia," In Focus IF10155, updated July 21, 2026. everycrsreport.com

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U.S. airstrikes in Somalia have increased sharply under the Trump Administration, with **over 130 strikes in 2025 and nearly 70 in the first half of 2026**. AFRICOM continues to report that the strikes are **done in coordination with Somalia's government**. Successive U.S. Administrations have termed **Al Shabaab an "associated force" of Al Qaeda** in the context of the 2001 Authorization for Use of Military Force (AUMF; P.L. 107-40) and have interpreted the AUMF as authorizing operations against the Islamic State.

💡 **WHAT THE LAST SENTENCE MEANS**

After 9/11, Congress passed a law (the AUMF) allowing the U.S. to fight al-Qaeda and groups connected to it. The U.S. says al-Shabaab counts. That's **why** the U.S. is bombing in Somalia, and it connects the strikes to al-Shabaab.

⚠ **WHY THE CARD STOPS THERE**

The next sentence says U.S. strikes killed al-Shabaab leaders, "**but** UN terrorism experts suggest" that may not weaken the group. Reading only the first half would change the author's meaning. That's called **clipping**, and it's cheating. Stopping before the whole sentence is fine.

Alternate Neg card (same report)

For the **"benefits without recognition"** contention:

NEG · Benefits without recognition — **CRS, 2026**

The U.S. already works with Somaliland without recognizing it.

CRS, 2026. Same citation as above.

U.S. officials have made several visits to Somaliland and discussed opportunities for further engagement, but the State Department reported to Congress in 2026 that **the United States continues to recognize "the sovereignty and territorial integrity of the Federal Republic of Somalia, which includes the region of Somaliland."**

✧ How to tell if a source is credible

1. **Who wrote it?** An expert, reporter or government official is good. An anonymous blog is not.
2. **Who published it?** A well-known news outlet, think tank or government site is good.
3. **Is it selling something?** Groups lobbying for Somaliland or for Somalia are biased. Judges notice.

Type	Good examples
News	AP, Reuters, BBC, VOA, Foreign Policy
Think tanks	Heritage Foundation, Council on Foreign Relations, Crisis Group, Brookings, FPRI
Government	Congressional Research Service, state.gov, congress.gov, africom.mil

Don't use as a card: Wikipedia (fine for background), personal blogs, social media, or sites run by Somaliland or Somalia advocates.

Notes on specific sources

- **Middle East Eye:** a real London-based news site, but with a point of view (its headline called the 2026 report a "blow to Somaliland and Israel"). Quote facts, not opinions, and credit the government report it describes.
- **AFRICOM:** the U.S. military reporting on itself. Reliable for when and where strikes happened, but it may make itself look good. Human rights groups have found civilian deaths it didn't report at first. VERIFY
- **CRS:** the gold standard. Neutral, written for Congress, and no judge will question it.

✧ How to cut a card

- ◇ Copy the paragraph exactly. Don't change any words.
- ◇ Remove footnotes and footnote numbers (they're citations, not the argument).
- ◇ Make sure the card actually **proves the tag**. If it doesn't name what you're arguing about (for example, al-Shabaab), add the sentence that does.
- ◇ Highlight only the key words, and read only those.
- ◇ Never stop in the middle of a "but" or "however." That's clipping.
- ◇ Put the year in the cite, even when the card is older.
- ◇ Proofread for "Somali" vs. "Somalia."

✦ STEP 7

Cross-Ex Practice

Questions the other side might ask you. Answer out loud first, then open the model answer.

⚠ **USE YOUR OWN WORDS**

The model answers show the **idea**. In a round you can't read from notes, so practice saying each answer your own way.

💡 **RULE #1 OF CROSS-EX**

Never accept their version of the facts. If a question ends with "*right?*", watch out. It's a trap to make you agree. Fix the false part first, then answer.

✧ When you're Affirmative

✦ **"In 2023 Somaliland lost Las Anod. So it doesn't control its territory, right?"**

"**No.** Somaliland still controls most of its land, including its capital and its main port. And recognized countries have border disputes too: India and Pakistan both claim Kashmir. That isn't a reason to deny recognition."

✦ **"The U.S. recognizes lots of countries that aren't democracies. Why does democracy matter?"**

"Democracy isn't the only reason. It's one good reason among several. Somaliland also meets the Montevideo test and sits in a key location." *(When they attack one reason, don't over-defend it. Point to your others.)*

- **"The U.S. doesn't recognize Taiwan either. So why would siding with Taiwan earn Somaliland recognition?"**

  "The U.S. doesn't officially recognize Taiwan, but it still supports Taiwan strongly. Somaliland took a real risk to stand with a U.S. friend, and partners who take risks for us deserve support."

- **"Somaliland chose to join Somalia in 1960. Why should it get to leave?"**

  "The union was never properly ratified, and northerners voted against the 1961 constitution. And choosing to join doesn't mean accepting being bombed by your own government. Somalia broke the deal."

- **"Can't the U.S. just use Berbera without recognizing Somaliland?"**

  "For short visits, maybe. But a real long-term base deal needs an official agreement with a recognized government. Without one, any deal can be dropped at any time."

- **"Your Heritage evidence is from 2021. Isn't it outdated?"**

  "The key facts haven't changed. China's base is still in Djibouti, right next to ours. Old evidence is fine when the facts are still true."

- **"The African Union says recognizing Somaliland is a dangerous precedent. Aren't they the experts on Africa?"**

  "The AU's own fact-finding mission in 2005 called Somaliland's case 'historically unique and self-justified.' The AU just never acted on its own report."

When you're Negative

- **"Somaliland meets all four Montevideo criteria. Isn't it already a country?"**

  "Even if it acts like one, recognition is a **choice** the U.S. makes based on its interests. And Somaliland doesn't control all the land it claims, as Las Anod shows."

✦ **"Somalia needs U.S. help against al-Shabaab. It would never cut ties, right?"**

"**Not necessarily.** Somalia doesn't have to fully cut ties to hurt us. It could limit where U.S. forces operate, or turn to Turkey, Egypt or China. Why take the chance?"

✦ **"How would recognizing Somaliland hurt Americans?"**

"If Somalia stops working with the U.S. against al-Shabaab, the group could grow stronger in East Africa and put Americans there at risk." *(Don't say "terrorism in the U.S." You can't prove it.)*

✦ **"Eritrea and South Sudan broke away and Africa was fine. Why would Somaliland be different?"**

"Both held independence referendums that the country they left agreed to: Ethiopia accepted Eritrea's vote in 1993, and Sudan accepted South Sudan's in 2011 under a 2005 peace deal. Somalia has never agreed to let Somaliland go. Recognizing it anyway would mean taking sides in an unresolved dispute."

✦ **"The U.S. recognized Kosovo even though Serbia objected. Why not Somaliland?"**

"Kosovo was backed by most of Europe and NATO. With Somaliland, almost no one is on board. Even after Israel recognized it, not a single other country followed. The U.S. would be nearly alone."

✦ **"Your CRS evidence never says recognition would end the partnership. So where's the risk?"**

"It shows how much the fight depends on Somalia's cooperation: over 130 coordinated strikes in one year. And the White House itself warned in 2024 that a recognition deal 'threatens to disrupt the fight' against al-Shabaab."

✦ STEP 8

Debate Skills

The lessons that came up again and again while preparing this topic.

✧ 1. Claim → Proof → So what

Every argument needs all three. If you skip the "so what," the judge will think: "Okay... why should I care?"

Part	Example
Claim	Recognizing Somaliland could encourage other regions to break away.
Proof	Groups like the English-speaking regions in Cameroon already want to.
So what	That could lead to instability and more fighting in Africa.

✧ 2. Don't claim more than you can prove

❌ Overclaim	✅ Defendable
"It would cause terrorism in the U.S."	"It could put Americans in East Africa at risk."
"Recognition would not cause other breakaways."	"Recognition wouldn't set an example for other regions."
"Somaliland doesn't know its own borders."	"Somaliland doesn't control all the land it claims."
"Almost all U.S. allies are democracies."	"Many of America's closest allies, like the UK and Japan, are democracies."
"We'd get all the ports."	"Its president has offered the U.S. access to Berbera."
"The U.S. would gain dominance."	"The U.S. would gain presence and influence."
"Somalia would stop fighting al-Shabaab."	"Somalia could stop working with the U.S. against al-Shabaab."

Helpful words: **could**, **one reason**, **experts say**, **according to**.

✧ 3. Name names

Vague words like "they," "fight" and "danger" make the judge guess. Specific words make you sound like you know your stuff.

- Say **"al-Shabaab,"** not "terrorism."
- Say **"Berbera,"** not "many ports."
- Say **"in 1960"** and **"in 2024,"** not "before" and "recently."
- Say **"the English-speaking regions in Cameroon,"** not "other countries."

✧ 4. Think one step ahead

Every argument goes back and forth. Before a round, ask yourself: "What will they say to this, and what will I say back?"

NEG "If Somaliland breaks away, others will copy it."

AFF "Somaliland is different. It was a separate colony and briefly independent."

NEG "Other groups won't care about those details. They'll see that breaking away worked. And even Somaliland's own borders are disputed."

✧ 5. Your case is a table with several legs

When they attack one reason, don't over-defend it. Say it's **one** of your reasons, then point to your others.

✧ 6. Use the other side's own sources

If Somaliland's friends say "we're unique," the judge thinks "of course they'd say that." If Somaliland's **opponents** (the AU) said it, the judge thinks "wow, even they admit it."

✧ 7. End with a sharp question

A rhetorical question puts the other side on the spot:

- "Somaliland doesn't even control all the land it claims, so **which borders would the U.S. be recognizing?**"
- "We're already getting the benefits, so **why take the risks?**"

✧ 8. Building your speech

Like the school-provided openings, use **two contentions** per side:

	Contention 1	Contention 2
AFF	It's already a real, democratic country	Its case is unique, so it won't spark more breakaways
NEG	We already get the benefits	It risks the fight against al-Shabaab

For each contention: **tag** → **explanation in your own words** → **evidence card** → **so what**.

✧ Before the round

- ◇ Every argument has a claim, proof and so what
- ◇ No overclaims ("could," not "will")
- ◇ Specific names, places and dates
- ◇ Tags written in my own words
- ◇ "Somalia" (country) vs. "Somali" (describing word) proofread
- ◇ Every VERIFY item checked or removed
- ◇ Practiced the cross-ex questions out loud

✦ STEP 9

Sources

Every link used to build this package, grouped by type, plus a list of facts to double-check before quoting.

✧ Still to verify

🔍 CHECK THESE BEFORE QUOTING

- **AU 2005 mission quote** ("historically unique and self-justified"): found quoted in several articles, but the original report wasn't opened.
- **1988 death toll**: estimates vary widely. Say "tens of thousands" unless you find a solid source.
- **1961 constitution vote**: sources agree the north mostly voted no or boycotted, but disagree on the date and numbers.
- **China's Djibouti base in 2025–26**: no recent coverage found. Find a newer article to support the 2021 Heritage card.
- **2020 al-Shabaab attack in Kenya** (three Americans killed): confirm before quoting.
- **Meservey's job title**: likely "Senior Policy Analyst for Africa and the Middle East." Check the report's byline.
- **AFRICOM civilian casualties**: confirm the Amnesty International findings before using them.

✧ Evidence card sources

- Heritage Foundation: The U.S. Should Recognize Somaliland (Meservey, Oct 19, 2021)
- Congressional Research Service: Somalia, IF10155 (updated July 21, 2026)

✧ Government and official

- AFRICOM press release on strikes targeting al-Shabaab
- Montevideo Convention text (Yale Avalon Project)
- Joint communiqué of the Somalia–Eritrea–Egypt summit (Somali presidency, Oct 2024)

✧ News

- VOA: White House 'troubled' by Ethiopia-Somaliland port deal (Jan 2024)
- Courthouse News: White House concerned over Ethiopia-Somaliland agreement
- Middle East Eye: US reaffirms Somali sovereignty (2026)
- Army Times: US carried out nearly 50 strikes in Somalia so far this year (Apr 2026)
- AOL: Israel becomes first country to recognize Somaliland
- Ahram Online: Somaliland president in Washington (Sept 2026)
- Dawan Africa: Somaliland president meets Ted Cruz
- Dawan Africa: Somali president arrives in Las Anod (Jan 2026)
- Africa Check: No, the US has not recognised Somaliland
- Arab News: Egypt, Eritrea, Somalia forge closer ties (Oct 2024)
- Israel Hayom: Somaliland, Red Sea bases and recognition (Aug 2026)

✧ Analysis and opinion

- Foreign Policy: Stop Trying to Make Somaliland Happen (Sept 2025, against recognition)
- Foreign Policy: Somaliland, Somalia, the Houthis and the U.S. (Sept 2026)
- Washington Examiner: Israel got it right: Somaliland is the strategic ally Trump needs now (Oct 2026, for recognition)
- New Lines Magazine: Somaliland's uphill struggle for recognition in Washington
- PISM: Israel's Recognition of Somaliland Heightens Tensions (Jan 2026)
- RANE: U.S. reaffirms One Somalia policy but eyes further cooperation (June 2026)
- New America: AFRICOM confirms 63 strikes in Somalia in 2026
- Rift Valley Institute: SSC-Khaatumo: significance and implications
- The EastAfrican: Why is the AU contradicting its own report?
- UNPO: AU mission to Somaliland says recognition overdue

✧ Background only (not for cards)

- Wikipedia: Montevideo Convention
- Wikipedia: North East State of Somalia
- Wikipedia: 2003 Somaliland presidential election

- Wikipedia: International recognition of Somaliland
